

ICELAND

Capital city: Reykjavik
Area: 39,768 sq miles (103,000 sq km)
Population: 290,000
Official language: Icelandic
Major religions: Christian 94%, other 6%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Icelandic krónur
Adult literacy rate: 99%
Life expectancy: 80 years
People per doctor: 286
Televisions: 320 per 1,000 people

CAPE VERDE

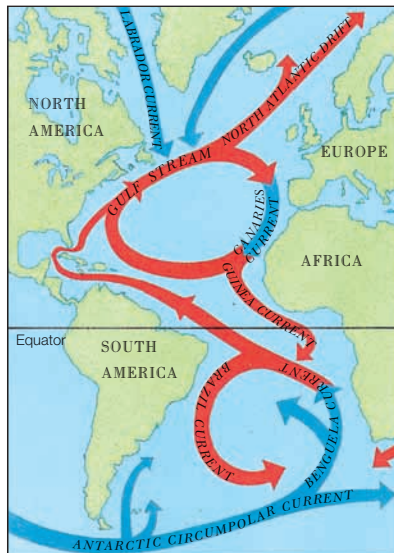
Capital city: Praia
Area: 1,556 sq miles (4,030 sq km)
Population: 463,000
Official language: Portuguese
Major religions: Christian 98%, other 2%
Government: Multiparty democracy
Currency: Cape Verde escudo
Adult literacy rate: 76%
Life expectancy: 69 years
People per doctor: 5,000
Televisions: 4 per 1,000 people

Key to currents

Warm currents
 Cold currents

THE ATLANTIC OCEAN

BORDERED BY THE AMERICAS to the west and Africa and Europe to the east, the Atlantic covers about 31.7 million sq miles (82 million sq km), one-fifth of the Earth's surface. Down the ocean's entire length runs the Mid-Atlantic Ridge, a great underwater mountain chain formed by lava that oozes up from the seabed, cools, and then hardens. Some peaks break the surface to form volcanic islands. The Atlantic contains some of the world's richest fishing grounds, but is also the most polluted ocean because of the industry around its shores.



OCEAN CURRENTS

Water in the oceans is never still but moves in huge belts of water called currents. In the open ocean, surface winds drive these currents in vast, roughly circular patterns. The currents can be as warm as 86°F (30°C) or as cold as 30°F (-2°C), and affect the world's weather. Warm water from the Equator moves toward the cooler poles, helping spread warmth across the globe.



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The volcanic island of Iceland is part of the Mid-Atlantic Ridge. Intense heat generated deep underground creates bubbling hot springs and mud pools. Iceland has the most *solfataras* (volcanic vents) and hot springs in the world, and many of its towns are heated by underground hot water. Cape Verde, off the west coast of Africa, is also volcanic.



FISHING

About 90 percent of the world's fish live in the shallow waters of the continental shelves that surround land, feeding on the plankton that live there. Over the past 20 years, stocks of cod, herring, and other fish in the Atlantic have run low as the number and size of fishing fleets have grown.

ICEBERGS

Icebergs, which are made of frozen water, occur when warmer weather causes ice sheets and glaciers on icy coastlines to break up, or calve. At sea, icebergs are moved by the wind and ocean currents and can be a danger to ships. Icebergs vary in size from small Arctic growlers, which are about as big as a grand piano, to much larger Antarctic icebergs, which can be 5 miles (8 km) long.

GULF STREAM

The Gulf Stream is a warm current only about 60 miles (100 km) wide that moves across the North Atlantic. It raises the temperature of northern Europe and helps keep its ports ice-free in winter. It also allows tropical plants to grow in normally cool places, such as the west coast of Scotland.



Only about one-seventh of an iceberg shows above the surface of the ocean. The rest of the ice remains hidden below the waterline.

